SectorQ: Highly Scalable Pauli Propagation on HPC Systems with Window-Conserved Parity Sectors

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This paper presents *SectorQ*, a Pauli propagation system designed to compute the expectation values of quantum circuits with more than 100 qubits on GPU clusters. As tighter coefficient cutoffs increase the number of kept terms, the terms of a 127-qubit circuit exceed the memory of hundreds of GPUs, and the existing multi-GPU engine merges them across all GPUs after every gate. *SectorQ* introduces window-conserved parity sectors, which divide the terms by the parities that every gate of a window leaves unchanged and keep each new term in the same sector as its merge partner. With this design, *SectorQ* applies each window without exchanging terms between nodes, balances the sectors by choosing the parities at run time from a sample of the live terms, and holds the sectors in host memory beyond the capacity of the GPU memory. Our evaluation using seven circuits on up to 512 NVIDIA A100 GPUs shows that *SectorQ* reduces the simulation time of *cuPauliProp* on 16 GPUs by 4.4-9.7× and increases the largest finished problem on 512 GPUs by 140×.

1 Introduction

Quantum computers have advanced from demonstrations of quantum supremacy on sampling tasks to processors with more than 100 qubits that measure the expectation values of physical models [2, 10]. These expectation values are the output of quantum simulation, the application that motivates quantum computing in physics, chemistry, and materials science [7]. A 127-qubit processor, for example, measured the magnetization of a kicked Ising model at a scale beyond the exact classical methods [10]. This scale moves the comparison between quantum and classical computation from small benchmarks to the circuits of these applications. As a result, the range of expectation values that a classical computer can still produce has become a central question for the development of quantum computers.

Despite this progress, current processors remain noisy intermediate-scale quantum (NISQ) devices [14]. The noise of these devices biases every measured expectation value, and error mitigation recovers an estimate from repeated runs at amplified noise [10]. These estimates require an independent reference, and classical simulation on high-performance computing (HPC) systems provides this reference without noise. This reference verifies the hardware, calibrates the error mitigation, and tests quantum algorithms before they run on a processor. Thus, several groups simulated the 127-qubit experiment soon after its publication, with tensor networks and with Pauli propagation [3, 18].

Classical simulation of these circuits follows three approaches on HPC systems. State vector simulation stores all 2^n amplitudes of an n-qubit state, requiring 16 PiB for 50 qubits in double precision [8]. Tensor network simulation stores the state as a network of small tensors, and its cost grows with the entanglement of the circuit [18]. Pauli propagation tracks the observable, not the state, as a list of Pauli terms, and its cost follows the number of kept terms in place of the number of qubits [3, 17]. This cost extends Pauli propagation to circuits with more than 100 qubits, and NVIDIA and IBM now provide Pauli propagation in their quantum software stacks [13, 15]. Our work focuses on Pauli propagation, since its accuracy follows the resources of the system in place of the number of qubits.

The accuracy of Pauli propagation, however, requires far more terms than one GPU holds. A lower cutoff on the coefficients keeps more terms, and the terms grow within each layer of gates before the truncation removes the small ones. For example, the 127-qubit kicked Ising circuit retains up to 159 million terms at window boundaries at cutoff 10^{-5} and 11.9 billion at 10^{-6}, requiring about

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Table 1. Comparison with existing Pauli propagation systems (MN: Multi-Node, GPU: GPU Execution, LP: Locality-Preserving Partition, RP: Run-Time Partition from the Gates and the Live Terms, HM: Host Memory beyond GPU Memory)

System	Method	MN	GPU	LP	RP	HM
PauliPropagation.jl [17]	Pauli propagation, one node					
SPD [16]	Sparse Pauli dynamics		✓			
ORQA [5]	Structured distribution map	✓				
MonoProp [1]	Distributed Pauli propagation	✓				
cuPauliProp [13]	Global merge after every gate	✓	✓			
paulistrings-rs [12]	Fixed linear partition	✓	✓	✓		
***SectorQ* (Ours)**	**Window-conserved parity sectors**	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

6.4 GB and 475 GB of term storage before working buffers. These counts place Pauli propagation on HPC systems, and recent systems run it on GPU clusters and on the Fugaku supercomputer with 2^{17} processes [5, 13]. However, the existing systems show limited performance and scalability as the number of terms grows.

Existing distributed GPU engines face two limits, and the first is the global step after every gate. Since a new term may merge with a term on another GPU, the distributed mode of *cuPauliProp* coordinates the merge across GPUs after every gate [13]. This step adds a fixed cost to every gate, from 5.9 ms on 4 GPUs to 29.8 ms on 16 GPUs in *cuPauliProp*. The second limit is the GPU memory. Between two truncations, every rotation branches the terms, and the list grows to several times its size at the truncation. The merge of these terms also requires working space on the same GPU. As a result, *cuPauliProp* holds about 100 million kept terms on a GPU with 36 GB, and paulistrings-rs keeps its device partitions on the GPUs by the same rule [12]. A deferred merge reduces the global steps, but the unmerged copies of equal strings fill this memory faster. To summarize, these distributed GPU designs bind gate execution to global coordination and operator capacity to device storage, and our work aims to remove both constraints.

Many previous studies, as shown in Table 1, have optimized Pauli propagation from different algorithm and architecture perspectives. Single-node simulators reduce the cost of each gate with sparse data structures, symmetries of the circuit, and GPU kernels [3, 16, 17]. ORQA uses a structured distribution map to limit communication partners as it advances through generators [5], and MonoProp also supports distributed CPU propagation [1]. Distributed GPU engines keep the strings of each gate across all GPUs and merge them in a global step [13]. Linear partitions assign each string by parities of its bits, and these parities remain fixed for the whole run [12]. Theory on the commutator graph of a circuit also shows that the generators of the gates divide the Pauli strings into components that never mix [19].

SectorQ distinguishes itself from previous studies by recomputing the partition of the terms for every window of gates during the run. Previous systems merge the terms globally after every gate or fix the partition before the run, and these choices bind the exchange to the gates and the balance to rows chosen in advance. In contrast, *SectorQ* derives the parities that each window conserves from the generators of its gates, chooses among them by the balance of a sample of the live terms, and assigns each sector to one node for the whole window. Each GPU loads one sector at a time from the host memory of its node, and the terms move between nodes only at window boundaries. This design removes the global step after every gate and the bound of the GPU memory, and enables scalable performance across circuits, problem sizes, and GPU counts.

In this paper, we present *SectorQ*, a Pauli propagation system for GPU clusters that partitions the terms by the parities that a window of gates conserves. A rotation gate maps each term to itself and to its product with the generator of the gate, and every parity that the generator leaves unchanged assigns the same value to both terms. Specifically, *SectorQ* introduces 1) window-conserved parity sectors that the system recomputes for every window from the generators of its gates, 2) a run-time choice of the parities and the number of sectors from a sample of the live terms while the GPUs process the current window, and 3) a host-memory sector store from which each GPU loads one sector at a time. With these sectors, the terms move between nodes only at window boundaries, and the number of terms that *SectorQ* holds follows the host memory of all nodes. Our evaluation on up to 512 NVIDIA A100 GPUs of the Perlmutter supercomputer shows that *SectorQ* reduces the simulation time by 4.4-9.7× on 16 GPUs and increases the largest finished problem by 140× on 512 GPUs compared with *cuPauliProp*, the existing multi-GPU engine. We open-source *SectorQ* at: https://anonymous.4open.science/r/SectorQ

2 Background

2.1 Pauli Propagation beyond 100 Qubits

Classical simulation of a quantum circuit stores either the state or the observable. State vector simulation stores all 2^n amplitudes of the state, requiring 16 PiB for 50 qubits in double precision [8]. Tensor network simulation compresses the state into small tensors, and its cost grows with the entanglement of the circuit [18]. Pauli propagation tracks the observable, not the state, as a list of Pauli terms in the Heisenberg picture and computes its expectation value for circuits with more than 100 qubits [3, 17]. This list sets the cost of the simulation, and our work focuses on Pauli propagation, since its cost follows the number of kept terms in place of the number of qubits.

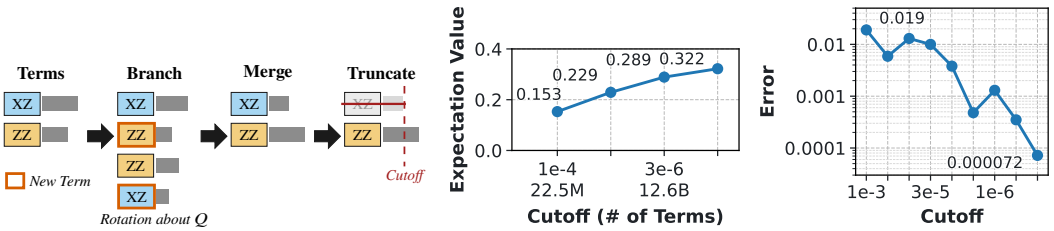
Branch, Merge, and Truncate. Each term of the list consists of a coefficient and a Pauli string, and the string maps to a bit vector with an x bit and a z bit for every qubit. With this bit vector, the product of two strings becomes the XOR of their bit vectors up to a phase. A rotation gate with generator Q keeps every term that commutes with Q and branches every anticommuting term P into P with $\cos\theta$ and $P \oplus Q$ with $\sin\theta$. These branches can double the number of terms at every rotation. The merge then sums the coefficients of the terms with equal strings, and the truncation removes the terms with a coefficient magnitude below the cutoff. Clifford gates map each string to one string and keep the number of terms, and noise channels scale the coefficients (Figure 1).

Term Growth with Accuracy. The cutoff of the truncation sets the accuracy and the number of terms together. On a 30-qubit circuit with an exact answer, the error decreases from 0.019 at cutoff 10^{-3} to 0.00007 at cutoff 10^{-7}. On the 127-qubit kicked Ising circuit, the expectation value moves from 0.153 at cutoff 10^{-4} to 0.229 at 10^{-5} and 0.322 at 10^{-6}. The largest boundary count rises to 159 million terms at cutoff 10^{-5} and 11.9 billion at 10^{-6}. The latter occupies about 475 GB at 40 bytes per term before execution buffers. Within a window, we also sum the maximum term count reached by each sector execution. The largest of these sums reaches 1.4 billion and 100 billion at the two cutoffs, respectively. This counter captures intermediate expansion across sector executions, not a simultaneous memory footprint.

Merge before Truncation. The truncation must see the merged coefficient of each string. Equal strings that arise from different parents carry parts of one coefficient, and each part can lie below the cutoff although their sum exceeds it. A truncation of these unmerged parts removes this sum and changes the answer. For example, the 127-qubit kicked Ising circuit at cutoff 10^{-4} yields 0.194-0.283 when the truncation sees unmerged parts, whereas the merged run yields 0.1531. The merge partner of a new term depends on the gate that creates it and not on the location of its parent.

Table 2. Distribution of state vector simulation and Pauli propagation

	State Vector	Pauli Propagation
Data	2^n amplitudes of fixed size	Terms that grow and shrink at every gate
Location of the data	Fixed amplitude indices	Live strings and counts emerge at run time
Work of a gate	Updates fixed positions	Creates, merges, and removes strings
Communication	Gates on the qubits of the index	Every gate that may create a remote string
Limit	Memory of 2^n amplitudes	Number of kept terms



(a) Operations of one gate (b) Kicked Ising value (c) 30-qubit TFIM error

Fig. 1. Operations and accuracy of Pauli propagation

An arbitrary distribution of the parents does not guarantee that their merge partners are local. A locality-preserving partition must account for the generators that create these partners (Table 2).

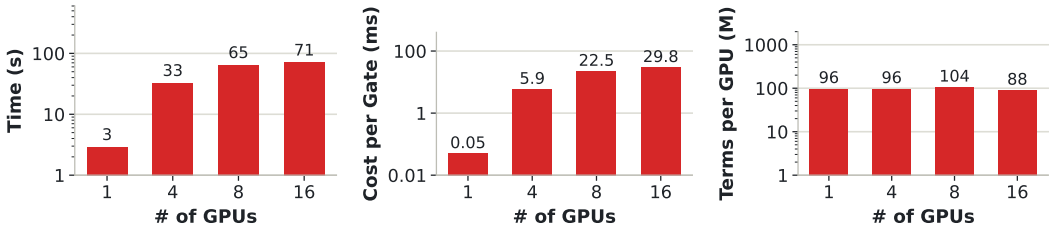
These two bottlenecks intensify at scale. The terms of an accurate run must spread over the GPUs of many nodes, whereas every equal string must meet its merge partners before each truncation. Existing systems run Pauli propagation on one device [3, 17], merge the terms across all GPUs after every gate [13], or fix the partition of the strings before the run [12]. A partition that follows both the gates and the live terms across nodes is not available in these systems.

2.2 Challenges in Distributed Pauli Propagation

Existing distributed systems merge the terms across all GPUs after every gate or partition the strings by rules fixed before the run [5, 12, 13]. We measure the first design with *cuPauliProp* v0.5.0 on the 127-qubit kicked Ising circuit and NVIDIA A100 GPUs, and the measurement exposes two challenges, a global step after every gate and a capacity bound by the GPU memory.

Global Step after Every Gate. *cuPauliProp* merges the terms of every gate in a global step, since a new term may merge with a term on any GPU. Each MPI rank applies the gate to its terms and calls allgather 22 times to merge and redistribute the terms with all other ranks, and 57% of the gates have no term to exchange. This global step adds a fixed cost of 5.9, 22.5, and 29.8 ms per gate on 4, 8, and 16 GPUs, against 0.05-0.8 ms on one GPU (Figure 2). As a result, a run with 22.5 million terms takes 2.9-3.2 s on one GPU and 33-48, 65, and 71 s on 4, 8, and 16 GPUs. The GPUs compute during 9% of this run, and the terms remain evenly spread at 1.001 times the mean on the largest rank. Thus, the cost of the global step, not an imbalance of the terms, slows the run as GPUs are added.

Capacity Bound by the GPU Memory. *cuPauliProp* also keeps all terms of every gate in GPU memory. Within a group of consecutive gates, the number of terms rises to 2.9-36 times its value at the start of the group in the seven circuits, and the merge requires working space next to these terms. As a result, *cuPauliProp* runs out of memory at 88-104 million terms per rank on 1 to 16



(a) Run time (b) Fixed cost per gate (c) Terms per GPU at failure

Fig. 2. Distributed mode of *cuPauliProp*

GPUs, and these kept terms occupy about 4 GB of the 36 GB that it uses on each GPU. A deferred merge reduces the global steps, but its unmerged copies exceed the memory of 16 GPUs on two of the seven circuits. A run without the global merge does not lift this bound and returns a wrong answer, 0.1675 on 4 GPUs and 0.189 on 16 GPUs against 0.1531, since its truncation discards parts of equal strings.

2.3 Opportunity in Parities Conserved by Windows

The two challenges require a partition that keeps every merge partner on the GPU of its parent without a global step. We examine where this partition exists with the generators of the seven circuits and with the terms of the kicked Ising circuit.

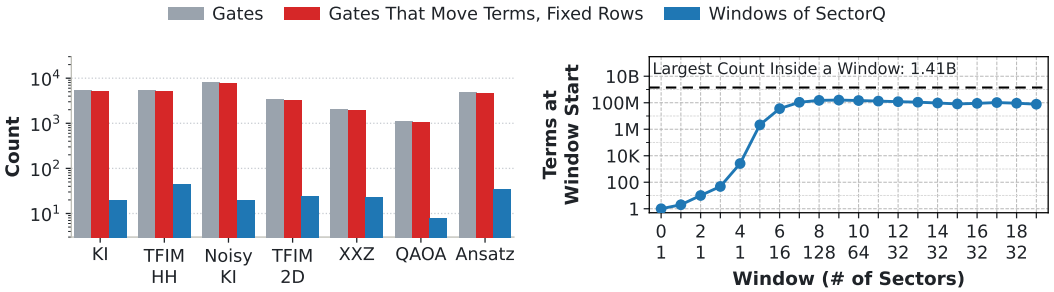
Parities Conserved by Windows of Gates. A rotation with generator Q changes a term P into $P \oplus Q$, and every parity r with $r \cdot Q = 0$ assigns the same value to both terms. A group of consecutive gates, a window, conserves every parity orthogonal to all of its generators, and these parities divide the terms into sectors that keep the merge partners together. We count the windows in the seven circuits under the rule that a window grows while at least n conserved parities remain (Table 3). The circuits with 1,100-7,960 gates form 8-45 windows, and a partition by window parities moves terms only at the window boundaries, 89-398 times fewer than the gates. In contrast, the whole circuit conserves at most two parities, and every term keeps the value of the observable on these parities. Thus, no parity divides the terms for the whole run, and the partition must change between windows.

Fixed Partitions Move Terms. Existing partitions fix their parities for the whole run and apply every gate to the terms [12]. Under these partitions, every gate that changes a fixed parity moves terms between processes. With 16 parts, rows over all bits move terms at 93-96% of the gates of the seven circuits, and rows over only the x bits or only the z bits move terms at 31-95% of the gates. On the kicked Ising circuit, random rows change the owner of 94% of the terms at a layer of two-qubit gates, and rows over lattice regions reduce this share to 68-89% with the largest of 16 parts at 1.65-3.37 times the mean. The library that implements these partitions keeps its rows for the whole run, since a changed row would move the owner of every term, and it lists the automatic choice of rows as an open problem [12].

Partitions that Follow the Run. The parities of each window follow its gates, and the balance of the sectors follows the live terms. On the kicked Ising circuit at cutoff 10^{-5}, the terms at the start of a window grow from 1 to 159 million over the run, and the first windows hold too few terms to divide (Figure 3). The terms within a window then rise to 2.9-36 times this start in the seven circuits, and the sectors of a balanced partition differ from window to window. As a result, only the live terms of the run determine the number of sectors and the parities that balance them. Thus,

Table 3. Windows and fixed partitions in seven circuits (16 parts, rows fixed without a Clifford frame)

Circuit	Gates	Windows	Gates per Window	Moving Gates (Random Rows)	Moving Gates (z Rows)
Kicked Ising	5,420	20	271	94%	50%
TFIM heavy-hex	5,420	45	120	93%	50%
Noisy kicked Ising	7,960	20	398	95%	50%
TFIM 11×11	3,410	24	142	94%	60%
XXZ 8×8	2,048	23	89	94%	62%
QAOA	1,100	8	138	94%	60%
Ansatz	4,784	34	141	96%	95%



(a) Gates and windows

(b) Terms at window starts

Fig. 3. Windows of gates in seven circuits

Table 4. Requirements of distributed Pauli propagation

#	Requirement	Evidence
R1	Merge every equal string before each truncation	Unmerged parts change the answer
R2	No coordination among GPUs during the gates	The fixed cost per gate grows with the GPUs
R3	No accumulation of unmerged copies	A deferred merge exceeds the GPU memory
R4	A partition recomputed during the run	Fixed rows move terms at 31-96% of the gates
R5	A capacity beyond the GPU memory	Kept terms fill 4 of 36 GB on one GPU
R6	No loss on small problems	0.42 s on one GPU becomes 32-47 s on four

distributed Pauli propagation requires a partition that the system recomputes for every window from its gates and from the live terms during the run.

These observations define six requirements for distributed Pauli propagation, listed in Table 4. A partition that keeps every merge partner in the part of its parent satisfies the first three requirements together.

3 SectorQ Design

SectorQ addresses the requirements in Table 4 with three mechanisms. Window-conserved parity sectors keep merge partners together throughout a group of gates. Runtime re-sectoring selects the next partition from the gates and the live terms during execution. Host-memory sector execution separates the stored expansion from the working set of each GPU and redistributes terms at window boundaries.

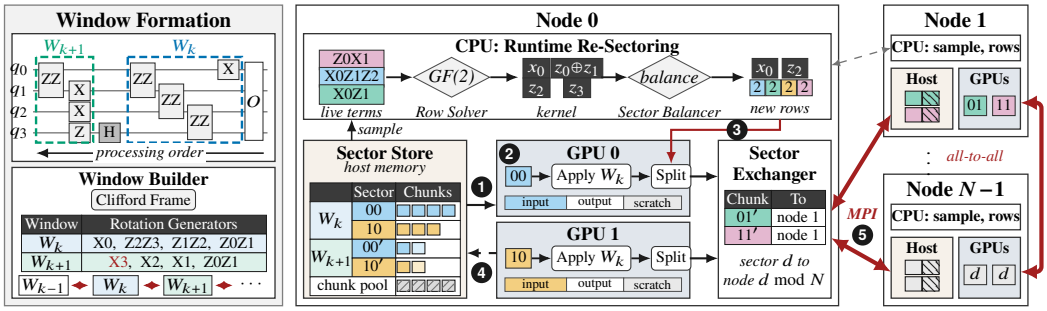


Fig. 4. Overall architecture of *SectorQ*

3.1 Overall Architecture

Figure 4 shows the circuit processing and the execution loop on each node. The CPU constructs windows and selects their rows, host memory holds the sectors, and each GPU processes one sector at a time.

Window Formation. The *Window Builder* first expresses the circuit in the processing order of the observable. A Clifford frame absorbs eligible Clifford gates and transforms the generators of subsequent rotations, preserving the action on the observable. For example, a Hadamard maps the generator Z_3 to X_3 in the illustrated circuit. For each window, the builder accumulates the span of the branching generators over GF(2) and stops before its dimension exceeds the number of qubits. This bound reserves a space of conserved rows from which the runtime can select a partition. The default boundary moves to the last scheduled truncation in the second half of the window when one is available, reducing the terms that require redistribution. Clifford operations that remain explicit transform generators into a common coordinate system for this calculation. The resulting window defines a sequence of operations and a space of valid partitions, with the particular rows selected during execution.

Window Loop. Each node follows the numbered steps in Figure 4. At step (1), a GPU worker loads one sector from the *Sector Store* in host memory. At step (2), its *Sector Executor* applies the current window, including the merges and scheduled truncations. During these operations, *Runtime Re-Sectoring* uses the CPU to select the rows of the next window. At step (3), the worker uses these rows to partition its output on the GPU. Step (4) appends output chunks to the host lists of the next sectors. The *Sector Exchanger* transfers the remote lists at step (5), assigning sector d to node d mod N among N nodes. Each node then processes its received sectors with the same loop. The last window evaluates the observable against the input state and reduces the partial answers across nodes. Thus, the data path repeats by window and keeps the distributed merge outside the sequence of gates within a sector.

3.2 Window-Conserved Parity Sectors

The execution loop requires a partition that preserves merge locality through every operation of a window. Figure 5 illustrates this condition on four qubits and two parity rows.

Rows Conserved by a Window. A Pauli string has a binary representation $v = (x, z) \in \mathrm{GF}(2)^{2n}$, with its phase represented in the coefficient. For a row r, the parity is the binary inner product $r \cdot v$. A branching rotation with generator q creates strings v and $v \oplus q$. Their parities agree whenever $r \cdot q = 0$. The *Row Solver* computes the annihilator of the generator span with Gaussian elimination over GF(2). If that span has dimension d, its annihilator has dimension $2n - d$, at least n under

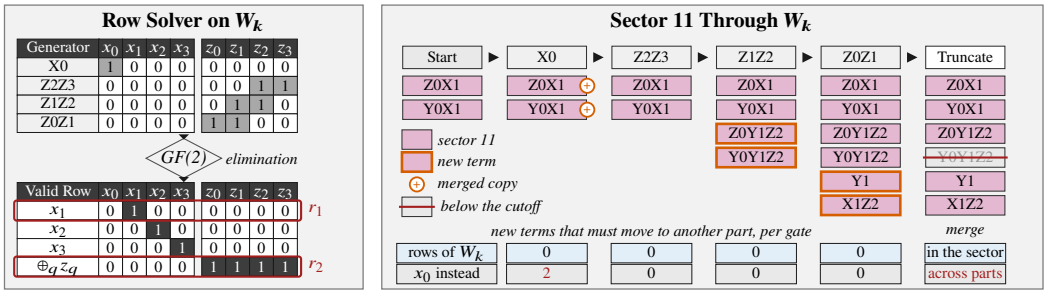


Fig. 5. Window-conserved parity sectors

the window rule. The selected rows form a matrix R, and the bit vector Rv labels the sector of v. This binary linear algebra is related to symmetry detection for qubit tapering [4]. Here its role is to partition the operator during one window, rather than remove qubits using a symmetry of the entire problem.

Merge Locality. Every descendant of a term retains its sector label through the branching rotations of the window. This property follows by induction from $R(v \oplus q) = Rv$ for each generator in the window. A coefficient change from a Pauli noise channel also preserves the string and its label. For an explicit Clifford operation, the row coordinates transform with the strings to preserve the same label. Equal strings have equal labels, and all contributions to a string therefore belong to one sector before truncation. Consequently, a merge and coefficient truncation within each complete sector produce the same operator as a global merge and truncation at the same operations, apart from floating-point summation order. In the example, the rows x_1 and $z_0 \oplus z_1 \oplus z_2 \oplus z_3$ label both Z_0X_1 and Y_0X_1 as sector 11. Their descendants remain in this sector through W_k, including terms that merge or disappear at a truncation.

Exchange Only at Window Boundaries. The next window can contain generators that violate the current rows. For example, X_1 in W_{k+1} changes the parity x_1 used by W_k. The runtime therefore computes a new matrix for W_{k+1} and regroups the output of W_k before the next window begins. This regrouping collects all fragments of each next sector on its owner, where equal strings meet before their next truncation. The construction differs from a fixed linear partition [12], whose rows can require a remote transfer at a gate that changes a partition label. It also differs from a partition based only on symmetries of the full circuit, since these symmetries need not distinguish the live terms. The window rule requires conservation only over the operations assigned to the current sector execution. Thus, the system obtains a new space of valid partitions at each boundary without changing the prescribed truncation schedule.

3.3 Runtime Re-Sectoring

Conservation determines which rows are valid, but the live terms determine their load balance. Figure 6 shows how the runtime selects the next rows while the GPUs process the current window.

Sampling the Live Terms. At the start of a window, each node samples strings from its host sectors with a regular stride determined by the global term count. The configured sample target is 200,000 terms across all nodes. The CPU applies the current window's bit-changing Clifford operations to these strings before the next partition is scored. This estimate omits branching and truncation, avoiding a second propagation of the sampled operator. The sample therefore approximates the coordinate distribution at the next boundary rather than predicting its exact population. An MPI gather collects the samples on rank zero, where the row solver and the *Sector Balancer* make a

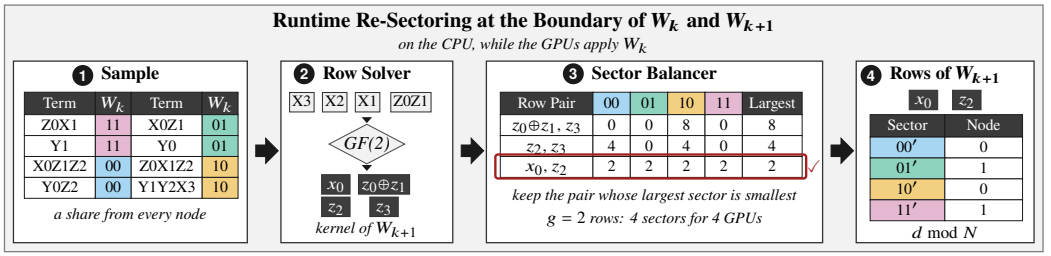


Fig. 6. Runtime re-sectoring at a window boundary

common decision for every node. A broadcast distributes the selected rows and window description. All workers consequently use the same sector labels, even though their local input sizes differ. The sample affects performance decisions only, since every selected row must satisfy the generator constraints independently of the sampled terms.

Balanced Row Selection. The sector balancer generates eight candidate row sets from random combinations of the annihilator basis. For each candidate, it counts sampled strings by sector and selects the set with the smallest largest count. The illustrated pairs produce largest counts of eight, four, and two, and the selected pair (x_0, z_2) divides the eight strings equally. The number of rows follows the estimated output size, the target terms per sector, and the available GPUs. The estimate uses the previous window's observed growth with a bounded growth factor. The runtime requests one task per GPU, or two when the preceding window exceeds the configured duration threshold, provided the resulting sectors remain sufficiently large. Early windows with few terms retain a smaller partition. A configurable cap bounds the number of sectors at a boundary. These choices adapt task size and placement to the evolving operator without assuming that any valid row set guarantees balanced work.

Overlap with the Running Window. The host sample is captured before the workers consume their input sectors. After the workers start, the CPU main thread gathers the sample, computes the next window, scores the candidate rows, and broadcasts the result. Workers need those rows only when they partition their output for the next window. A worker that reaches this point before the rows are ready waits on a local condition variable. The implementation records this wait separately from the CPU selection time, allowing the evaluation to distinguish overlapped work from exposed delay. The process therefore has no separate global optimization phase between successive GPU executions. In contrast to a circuit schedule based solely on gates, the row selection responds to the distribution of terms present during the run. Correctness depends on the conservation constraints, whereas the value of the sample and candidate search depends on the resulting execution time and sector balance.

3.4 Host-Memory Sector Execution and Exchange

The selected sectors are units of execution rather than permanent GPU allocations. Figure 7 shows their storage, processing, and transfer across a window boundary.

Chunked Sector Store. The sector store represents each sector as a list of fixed-capacity host chunks, with 262,144 terms per chunk by default. Each term contains a binary string and a double-precision coefficient. A pool retains pinned chunks for reuse after GPU transfers or MPI sends, avoiding repeated registration for every sector. The same chunk representation supports input loading, output collection, and reception from another node. A sector can contain multiple chunks, and a node can hold more sectors than it has GPUs. The live expansion therefore occupies host

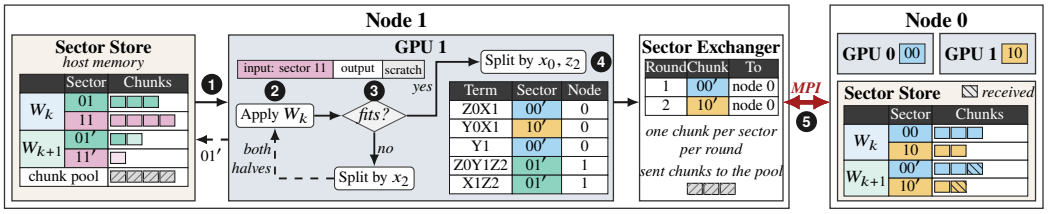


Fig. 7. Host-memory sector execution and boundary exchange. Pale sector colors denote filling chunks, black hatching received chunks, and gray hatching pooled chunks

memory while only the sectors under execution require GPU buffers. The total capacity depends on host storage, temporary output, and exchange buffers, rather than the sum of GPU buffers alone. Within a node, workers obtain sectors from a shared queue, initially ordered by decreasing size. This queue allows a GPU that finishes one sector to process another sector without a permanent binding between a sector and a device.

Sector Execution on GPUs. Each worker maintains input and output expansions together with the library workspace on its GPU. The worker loads a complete sector, applies its window, and performs the required merges before coefficient truncation. If the sector is too large to load with sufficient workspace, an additional valid row divides it in host memory. If growth exhausts the GPU buffers during execution, the worker partitions the current expansion using a further row conserved by the remaining operations. The resulting pieces return to the local queue with the operation position and any pending merge or truncation. Each piece resumes from that position, retaining the merge-locality argument within the finer partition. A split succeeds only if the available rows distinguish enough terms to fit the working set. The system therefore records both GPU and host splits, and the capacity claim includes the requirement that these finer sectors remain executable on a GPU.

Boundary Exchange. At the end of a window, a GPU partitions its surviving terms by the next matrix and copies them into host chunks. Chunks for local sectors remain on the node, and the sector exchanger sends the other chunks to their owners. The exchange first communicates counts and then transfers the chunks in rounds. For each sender and destination sector, a round transfers at most one chunk. After the outstanding requests complete, the sender returns transmitted chunks to the pool before the next round begins. The additional receive storage is therefore bounded by one round, and the request count depends on the active sender-sector pairs rather than all chunks in the expansion. At completion, the owner joins the received chunk lists into each complete next sector. A checkpoint can record this boundary state and its next-window description. Thus, the host representation supports both GPU execution and redistribution without a second full-size receive allocation.

3.5 Implementation

SectorQ implements the host runtime in C++ and the string partition operations in CUDA. Each MPI rank owns one node and creates one worker per GPU, with four GPUs per node in our experiments.

Runtime and Library Operations. Each worker uses *cuPauliProp* v0.5.0 on one GPU. The library operations cover rotations, Clifford gates, Pauli noise, merging, and truncation. The runtime supplies the sector contents and manages their placement, while the library supplies the arithmetic on each expansion. CUDA kernels evaluate the row parities and group output terms by their next sectors. The CPU handles binary elimination, sample scoring, the host chunk pool, and MPI exchange. Consecutive Pauli noise channels can share a library call up to the next truncation, preserving the

Table 5. Runtime parameters

Parameter	Setting
Sample target across nodes	200,000 terms
Candidate row sets	8
Target sector input	4 million terms, 6 million for kicked Ising
Tasks per GPU	1, or 2 after a window of at least 0.5 s
Default sector cap	256
Capacity experiment sector caps	1,024 or 4,096
Host chunk capacity	262,144 terms, 65,536 for selected large runs
GPU memory budget	90% of available device memory
Each expansion buffer	20% of the GPU memory budget
Coefficient truncation	Every 10 operations by default

scheduled coefficient decisions. On one GPU, an expansion below the target sector size can remain in device memory between windows. This path avoids a host transfer when no other worker could receive a sector. These execution choices complement the window partition but are not the source of its merge-locality property. Table 5 summarizes the default parameters and the larger sector caps used in the capacity experiments.

4 Evaluation

4.1 Evaluation Setup

We evaluate performance and capacity, the contribution of the design choices, numerical agreement, and sensitivity to execution parameters.

Hardware Specification. All experiments use NERSC Perlmutter GPU nodes, each with four NVIDIA A100 GPUs with 40 GB of device memory each, a 64-core CPU, and 256 GiB of host memory. The nodes communicate over the Slingshot network. GPU implementations use 90% of available device memory, approximately 36 GB per GPU. *SectorQ* assigns one MPI rank to each node and one worker to each GPU, whereas distributed *cuPauliProp* assigns one rank to each GPU. The largest configuration contains 128 nodes and 512 GPUs. CPU implementations use the same nodes as the corresponding GPU configuration. ORQA uses 64 ranks per node, MonoProp uses eight ranks with eight threads each, and threaded single-node implementations use 64 threads. Qiskit uses one thread. The comparisons identify the node count and execution devices rather than assuming equivalent CPU and GPU resources.

Evaluation Scope. The experiments measure Heisenberg-picture propagation that returns an observable expectation value. Unless stated otherwise, each setting is measured once with a 40-minute limit. The size and exact-reference experiments use a 20-minute limit, and capacity ladders allow *SectorQ* up to two hours per run. A ladder stops after memory exhaustion or its time limit, and an unexecuted point is not a measured failure. Times cover propagation rather than queue or process-launch delays, including initialization performed lazily within the timed region. Horizontal-axis term counts denote the largest population at a *SectorQ* window boundary under the stated truncation rule. These counts differ from intermediate expansion within a window and the final output size. Separate experiments assess numerical error and repeated-run variability. Thus, the main sweeps compare completed propagations under explicit input, truncation, resource, and timing conditions.

Circuits. The seven circuits in Table 3 vary the interaction graph, gate family, and observable. The principal workload is a 127-qubit heavy-hex kicked Ising circuit with 20 steps and rotation angle

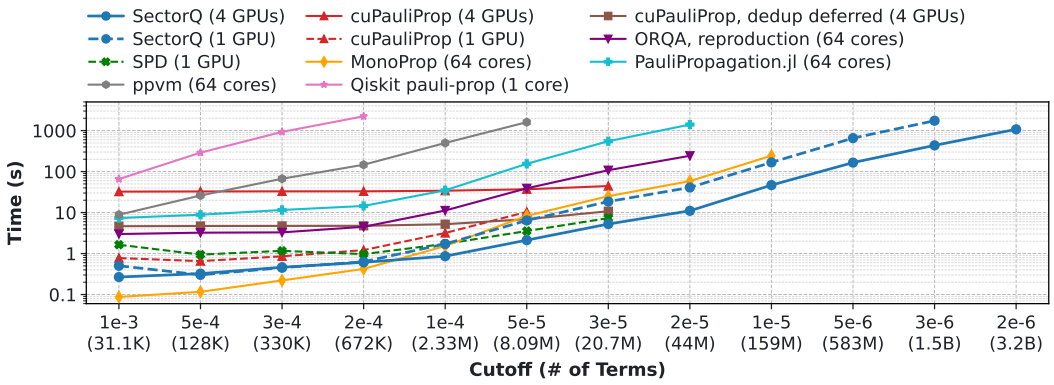


Fig. 8. Simulation time on one node (4 GPUs)

$\pi/4$. A second heavy-hex circuit uses transverse-field Ising model (TFIM) rotations at general angles, and a noisy variant adds depolarizing channels with probability 0.005. The remaining circuits are TFIM on an 11×11 lattice, XXZ on an 8×8 lattice, a 100-qubit QAOA circuit on a random regular graph, and a 100-qubit hardware-efficient ansatz. Their respective depths are 10 steps, 6 steps, 4 layers, and 16 layers. The observables include local magnetization and the edge sum of QAOA. Additional TFIM grids and kicked Ising depths vary circuit dimensions. Every comparison within a setting preserves the circuit, observable, and initial state.

Baselines. The primary baseline is *cuPauliProp* v0.5.0 with the original circuit and its default distributed mode. The second baseline uses a Clifford-frame input and defers global deduplication until truncation, with additional merges where required to fit memory. We report the fastest successful deferred interval among those tested. The paulistrings-rs comparison uses original gates and truncation after each operation in both systems to match its gate-level coefficient decisions. Other comparisons use the authors' SPD, MonoProp, PauliPropagation.jl, and ppvm implementations, Qiskit's Pauli propagation package, and our reproduction of ORQA. These external implementations, except paulistrings-rs, receive the exported Clifford-frame operation list. MonoProp has a different truncation rule, and its times do not represent equal-error comparisons. The ORQA results describe our reproduction rather than the authors' implementation. These distinctions apply throughout the performance comparisons below.

4.2 Performance Compared with Existing Systems

We compare implementations from one node to 128 GPUs, retaining separate experiments when their truncation schedules differ.

Single-Node Performance. Figure 8 establishes the arithmetic and capacity behavior before inter-node exchange. Across circuits that fit one GPU, the ratio of the *cuPauliProp* time to the *SectorQ* time is 0.6-1.5. SPD is up to 2.9 times faster on one GPU, but its kicked Ising run exhausts memory at cutoff 10^{-5}. At their shared cutoff 3×10^{-5}, *SectorQ* on four GPUs takes 5.25 s and distributed *cuPauliProp* takes 44.3 s. *SectorQ* also completes 3×10^{-6} in 436 s. At the largest shared settings across circuits, the four-GPU implementation is 108-269 times faster than PauliPropagation.jl, 157-755 than ppvm, and over 1,800 than single-threaded Qiskit. The ORQA reproduction is 18-71 times slower on the same node. MonoProp remains faster on several small settings below two seconds, including kicked Ising at 10^{-3}. The single-node result therefore includes both the small-problem advantages of other implementations and the broader executable range of *SectorQ*.

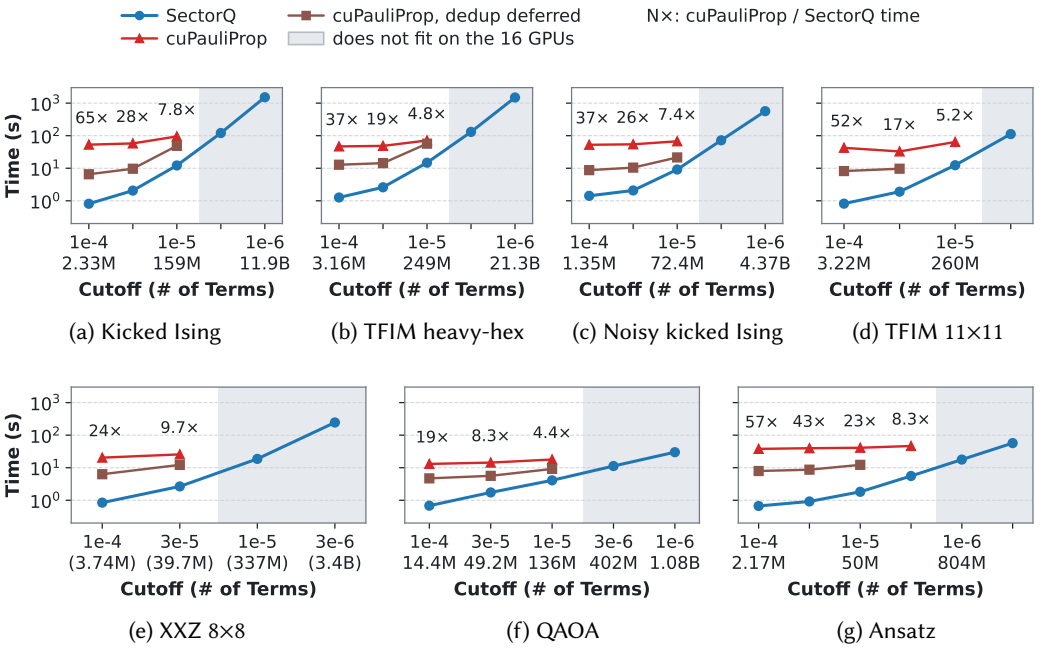
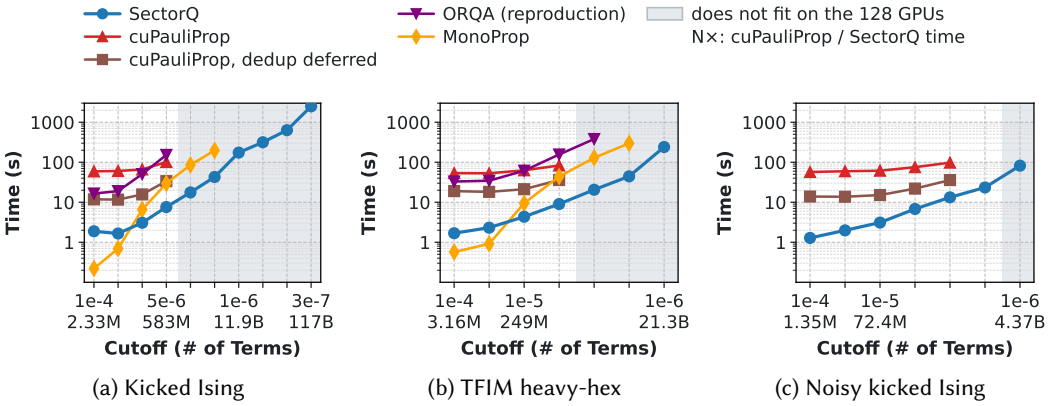


Fig. 9. Simulation time of seven circuits on 16 GPUs

Seven Circuits on 16 GPUs. Figure 9 compares the seven circuits on four nodes. At the largest setting completed by the original-circuit *cuPauliProp* baseline for each circuit, *SectorQ* is 4.4-9.7 times faster. Deferred deduplication remains 2.2-4.6 times slower at the shared settings and exhausts memory in two circuits at the primary baseline's largest completed setting. *SectorQ* completes lower cutoffs in all seven circuits, including TFIM and XXZ inputs without removable Clifford gates. The improvement therefore extends beyond Clifford preprocessing. The same measurements yield 17-130 ns per boundary term for *SectorQ* at settings above 100 million terms, compared with 908-39,000 ns for the primary baseline at cutoff 10^{-4}. This normalization divides propagation time by the largest boundary count, rather than measuring one gate application. It relates the time curves to the operator sizes already shown on their axes, with no assumption of identical work per term across circuits.

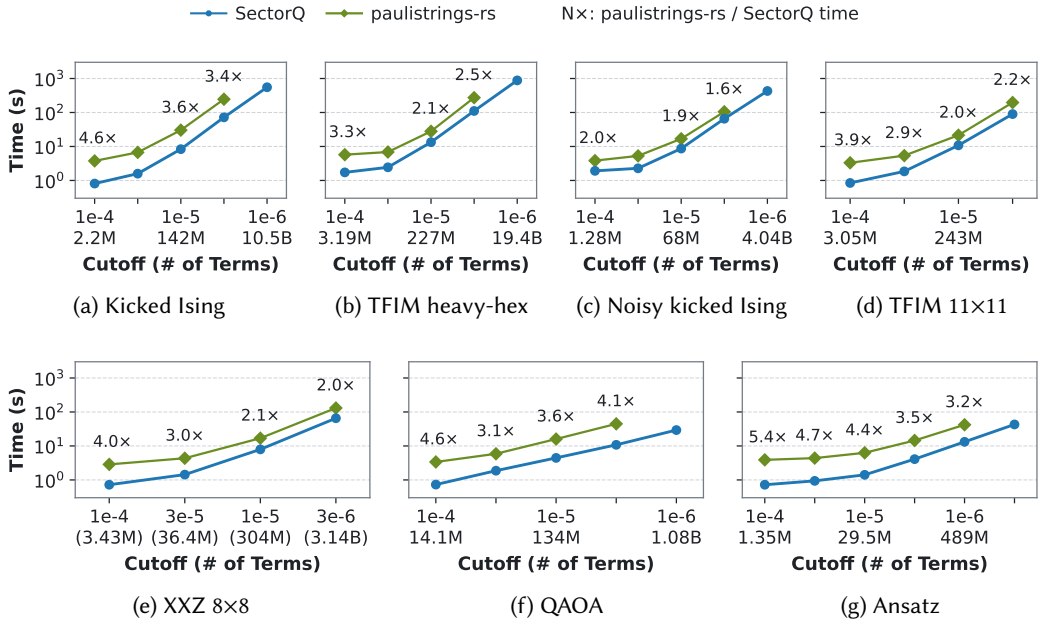
Three Circuits on 128 GPUs. Figure 10 extends the comparison to 32 nodes with completed original-circuit *cuPauliProp* sweeps. Kicked Ising and its noisy variant use those original inputs, while the TFIM input is identical with and without a Clifford frame. At the largest setting completed by the primary baseline in each sweep, *SectorQ* is 7.4-13.4 times faster. For kicked Ising at cutoff 5×10^{-6}, the times are about 7.6 and 101.6 s. The CPU comparisons use the same 32 nodes. MonoProp remains competitive at the smallest settings, subject to its different truncation rule. The additional CPU ladders remain incomplete, and their curves end at the last completed point. This comparison establishes the benefit relative to other systems at a larger resource count, while the scaling experiments below measure the effect of adding resources to *SectorQ* itself.

Fixed-Partition Implementation with Matched Truncation. Figure 11 compares *SectorQ* with paulistrings-rs on 16 GPUs using truncation after each operation and the same original circuit. The fixed partition uses the library's seeded rows. *SectorQ* is 1.6-5.4 times faster over all 30 shared settings and 1.6-4.1 times faster at the largest shared setting of each circuit. At the next tested



(a) Kicked Ising (b) TFIM heavy-hex (c) Noisy kicked Ising

Fig. 10. Three circuits on 128 GPUs with original-circuit primary baselines



(a) Kicked Ising (b) TFIM heavy-hex (c) Noisy kicked Ising (d) TFIM 11×11

(e) XXZ 8×8 (f) QAOA (g) Ansatz

Fig. 11. *SectorQ* and fixed linear partitions on 16 GPUs

cutoff in five circuits, paulistrings-rs exhausts GPU memory while *SectorQ* completes in 29-880 s. Small-setting times include any lazy GPU kernel compilation in the propagation call. These curves remain separate from Figure 9 because its default truncation interval differs. The comparison measures complete implementations, including their arithmetic and storage choices. Section 4.4 isolates row recomputation within the same engine, and Section 4.5 reports numerical agreement for the matched schedules.

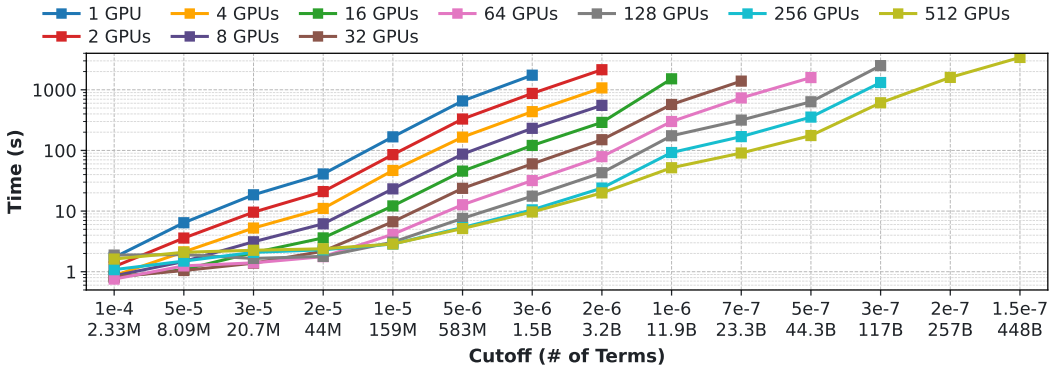


Fig. 12. Kicked Ising propagation from 1 to 512 GPUs

4.3 Scalability and Capacity

We vary the GPU count, circuit dimensions, and retained operator size to distinguish execution scaling from capacity.

Strong Scalability. For fixed large problems, *SectorQ* achieves speedups of 81-166 on 256 GPUs and 83-180 on 512 GPUs relative to one GPU. The representative settings are kicked Ising at cutoff 3×10^{-6} and heavy-hex TFIM and noisy kicked Ising at 5×10^{-6}. Figure 12 also shows the kicked Ising cutoff ladder from one to 512 GPUs. The gain beyond 256 GPUs is modest under the default cap of 256 sectors. At kicked Ising cutoff 3×10^{-6}, time decreases from 10.48 to 9.67 s. The trace has at most 256 nonempty sectors and no GPU splits, limiting concurrent sector execution below the 512 workers. Small problems also saturate, with cutoff 10^{-5} near three seconds from 128 GPUs onward. The time decomposition in Section 4.4 relates this limit to worker idle time and the remaining fixed costs.

Weak Scalability. Figure 13 increases the boundary term count with the GPU count by lowering the cutoff. Efficiency is boundary-term throughput per GPU relative to the corresponding one-GPU run, accounting for the counts actually produced. For the large load, *SectorQ* retains 80-88% of this throughput on 16 GPUs and 72-80% on 64 GPUs across the three circuits. The range falls to 23-38% on 512 GPUs under the default sector cap. The measured *cuPauliProp* large-load configurations exhaust GPU memory, whereas the small load permits time comparisons on both systems. On 16 GPUs, *SectorQ* is 8.1-12 times faster than the original-circuit baseline for the small load. CPU results appear where completed, with missing measurements omitted rather than interpreted as failures. Together, the weak and strong sweeps show that capacity continues to grow after the throughput per GPU decreases.

Circuit Size and Depth. Figure 14 varies the TFIM lattice size and kicked Ising depth on 16 GPUs. The lattice sweep covers 36-1,024 qubits with total magnetization as the observable, changing string length, graph size, and observable size together. At 1,024 qubits on a 32×32 lattice, *SectorQ* completes in 90.4 s and is 4.1 times faster than original-circuit *cuPauliProp*. This qubit count is the supported library limit in the experiment, not a measured limit of the partition rule. The depth sweep keeps the kicked Ising graph fixed and increases its Trotter steps. At 60 steps, *SectorQ* takes 160 s and is 50 times faster than the primary baseline. Longer propagation changes both the number of windows and the surviving operator, without implying proportional growth in retained terms. These two sweeps extend the result beyond the main circuit dimensions without extrapolating cost from qubit or gate count alone.

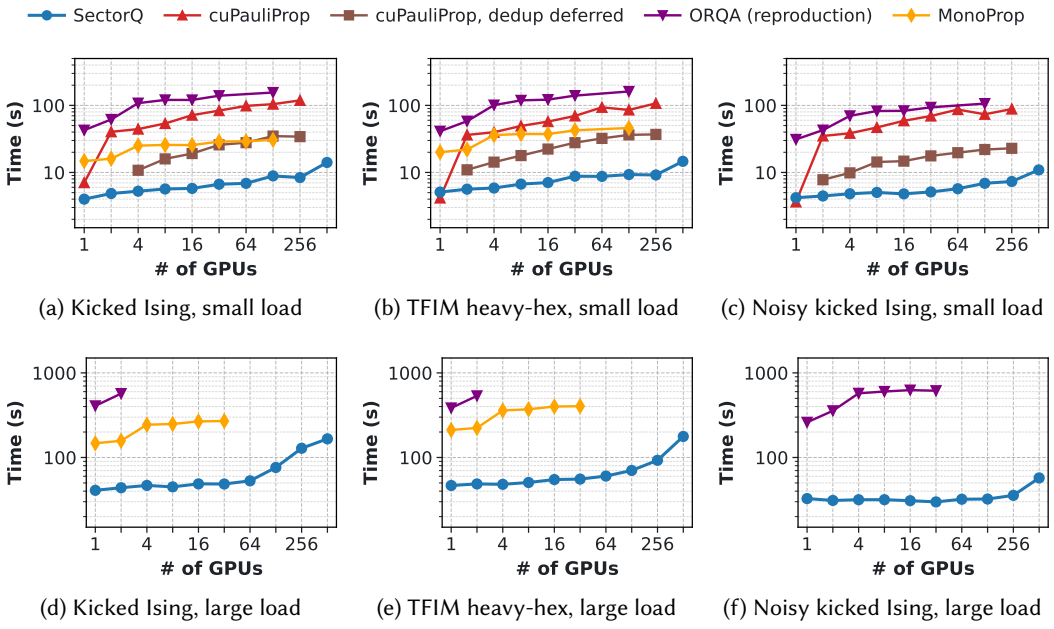


Fig. 13. Weak scaling from 1 to 512 GPUs

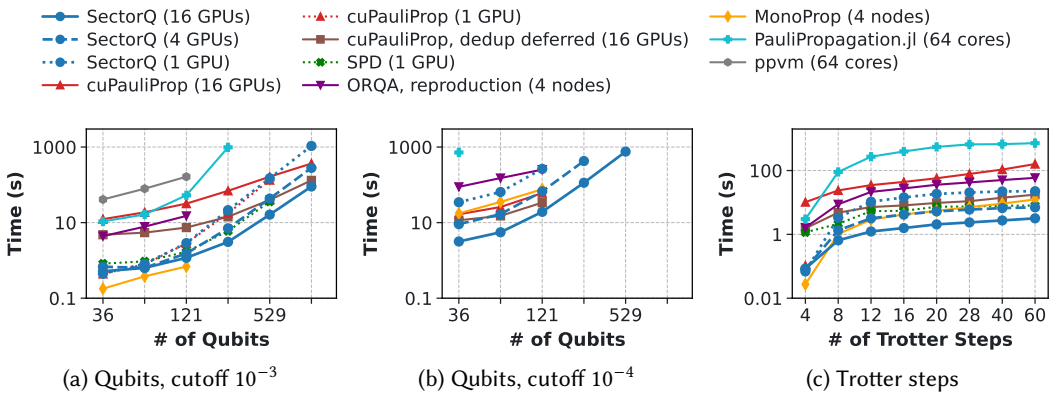


Fig. 14. Simulation time by circuit size and depth

Largest Operator and Host Memory. The capacity ladder reaches 448.2 billion boundary terms on 512 GPUs at cutoff 1.5×10^{-7}, completing in 3,413 s. The 17.9 TB expansion is 140 times larger than the largest completed original-circuit *cuPauliProp* setting on the same GPUs, 3.2 billion terms at 2×10^{-6}. The host chunk pool occupies 21,079 GiB across 128 nodes, 64% of installed host memory. This allocation includes reusable chunks and transient storage, rather than measuring the processes' total resident memory. Round-based exchange limits additional receive storage, and each sector must still admit a finer valid partition if its working set exceeds GPU memory. On 128 GPUs, *SectorQ* completes 117.5 billion terms. The 256-GPU endpoint remains under remeasurement after a stalled run. We distinguish completed runs, measured failures, and settings rejected from

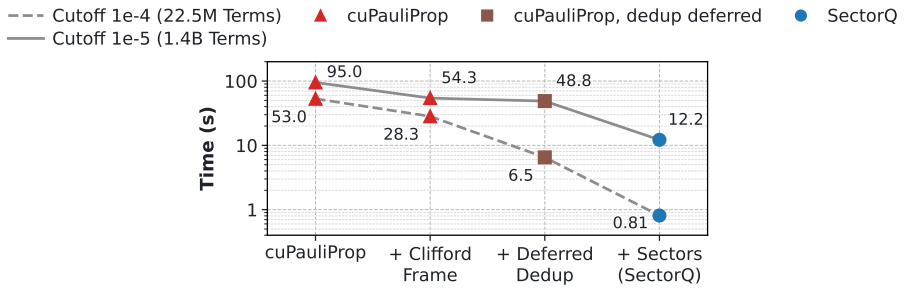


Fig. 15. Run time as each element is added on 16 GPUs

estimated storage requirements. The 140-fold comparison is specifically against *cuPauliProp* and does not establish a capacity advantage over every CPU implementation.

4.4 Contribution of the Design Choices

We combine controlled changes to the engine with time counters to identify the source and limits of the observed gains.

Preprocessing and Window Sectors. Figure 15 measures successive changes on kicked Ising at cutoff 10^{-5} and 16 GPUs. The original-circuit *cuPauliProp* baseline takes 95.0 s. A Clifford-frame input reduces time to 54.3 s, and deferred global deduplication reduces it to 48.8 s. Window-sector execution reaches 12.2 s with the same underlying library operations. This sequence separates the benefit of preprocessing from the execution structure built around those operations. It also shows that fewer global merges alone do not account for the observed time reduction. The fixed-row experiment below further tests whether one partition chosen in advance can obtain the same effect. Its recomputed run takes 11.9 s at this setting, from a separate allocation. We retain the two measurements separately rather than treating their small difference as the effect of another design change. Together, the experiments distinguish the execution mechanism from implementation differences between simulators.

Fixed versus Recomputed Rows. Figure 16 isolates row recomputation with the same Clifford frame, GPU operations, and truncation schedule. The fixed variant selects rows at the first partitioned window and retains them, ending a window when a rotation changes those rows. The recomputed variant selects rows for each window. Fixed rows are 2.4-17.0 times slower over 25 successful pairs on 16 GPUs and 1.3-14.8 times slower over 22 pairs on four GPUs. All pairs have identical printed expectation values. Several fixed-row runs exhaust host memory at lower cutoffs that the recomputed variant completes. Noisy kicked Ising is excluded because the fixed variant does not support its explicit Clifford operations between rotations. Table 6 connects the time difference to window count and traffic. For kicked Ising at 10^{-5}, recomputation reduces 878 windows to 20 and 698.5 GB to 45.2 GB, supporting the benefit of window-dependent partitions within one engine.

Time Breakdown across Scales. Figure 17 combines the 16-GPU cutoff sweeps with the 128-512 GPU decomposition at cutoff 3×10^{-6}. Worker counters are divided by the GPU count and compared with wall time. Library-call time is not sampled GPU utilization. For large 16-GPU settings, library operations account for 69-89% and inter-node exchange for 3-13%. The original-circuit *cuPauliProp* baseline separately records 39-44% of its large-setting time inside MPI calls. At kicked Ising cutoff 3×10^{-6}, average worker idle time rises from 9% to 40% of wall time as the GPU count increases from 256 to 512. The largest capacity run uses a higher sector cap and has a different composition, with 46% in library calls, 26% in exchange, and 9% in GPU-host copies. Its exchange includes 607 s

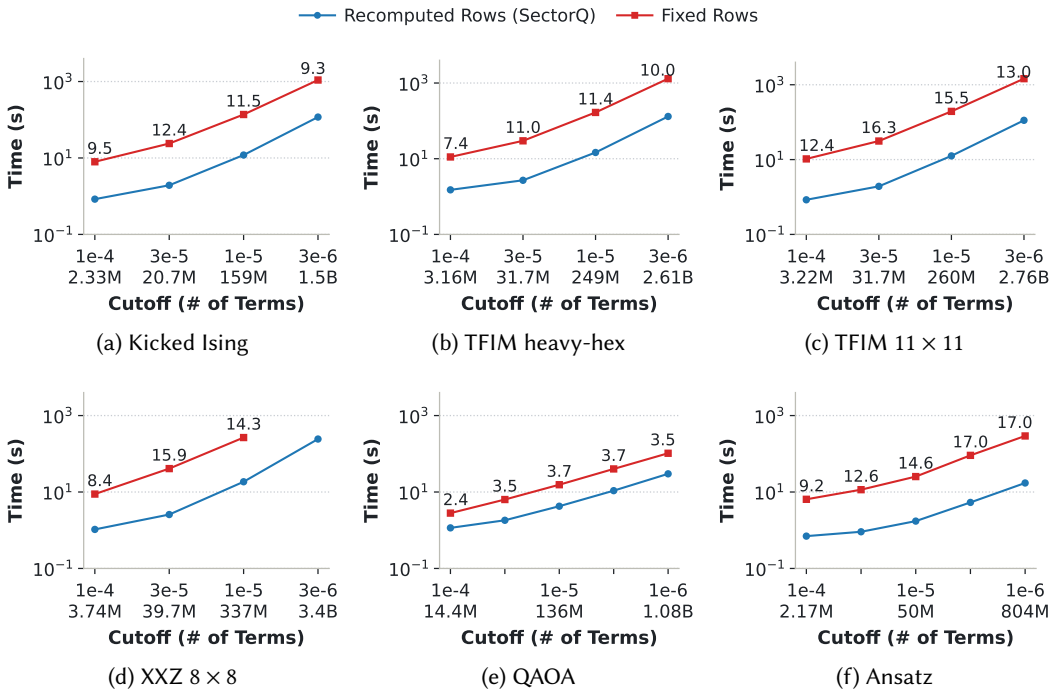


Fig. 16. Fixed and recomputed rows on 16 GPUs, with fixed-to-recomputed time ratios

Table 6. Windows and inter-node traffic at cutoff 10^{-5} on 16 GPUs

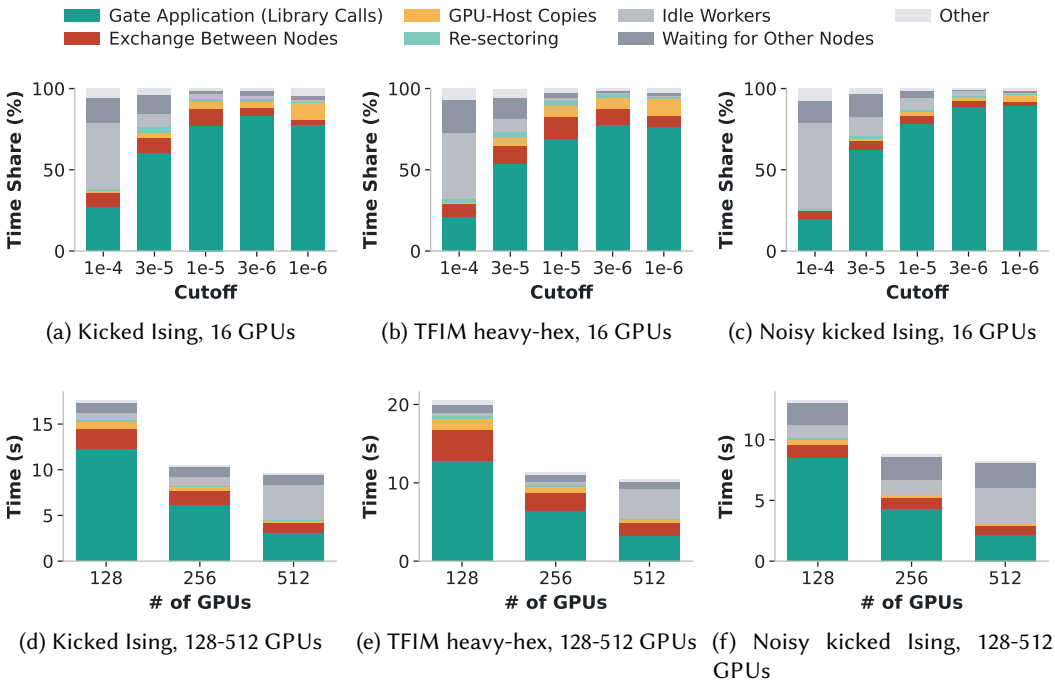
	Windows		Traffic (GB)	
Circuit	**Recomputed**	**Fixed**	**Recomputed**	**Fixed**
Kicked Ising	20	878	45.2	698.5
TFIM heavy-hex	45	2,241	79.0	342.2
TFIM 11 × 11	24	1,518	60.0	625.9
XXZ 8 × 8	23	1,155	44.8	2,369.9
QAOA	8	198	8.2	34.0
Ansatz	34	1,392	8.3	107.7

in transfer, 280 s in posting, and under two seconds in counts. These measurements distinguish insufficient task concurrency from exchange overhead.

4.5 Numerical Agreement and Accuracy

Numerical validation separates faithful distributed execution from the approximation introduced by coefficient truncation.

Agreement across Implementations. Across 68 circuit-cutoff settings with at least two successful runs under a common truncation rule, the largest absolute expectation difference is 4.9×10^{-11}. This comparison includes the single-GPU reference, distributed *cuPauliProp*, and external implementations with the same coefficient decisions. The largest difference occurs for QAOA's edge-sum observable. The separate gate-level truncation comparison with paulistrings-rs agrees within 4.7×10^{-11} over 75 completed settings on one, four, and 16 GPUs. *SectorQ* also preserves the printed



(a) Kicked Ising, 16 GPUs (b) TFIM heavy-hex, 16 GPUs (c) Noisy kicked Ising, 16 GPUs

(d) Kicked Ising, 128-512 GPUs (e) TFIM heavy-hex, 128-512 GPUs (f) Noisy kicked Ising, 128-512 GPUs

Fig. 17. Time by activity across problem sizes and GPU counts. Panels (a)-(c) show shares of wall time, and (d)-(f) show seconds at cutoff 3×10^{-6}

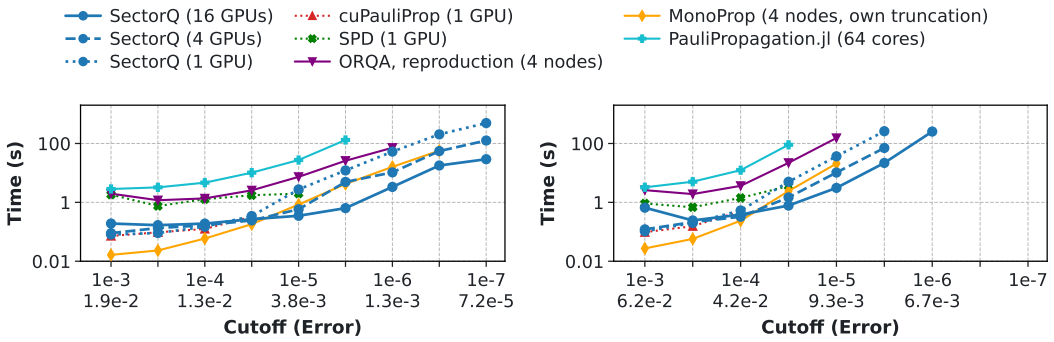
answer when sector count, GPU count, window rule, or device-memory budget changes. These checks exercise the partition, exchange, and merge operations across the evaluated configurations. They validate the distributed implementation of a specified truncation schedule, without establishing that the chosen cutoff approximates the exact quantum expectation sufficiently well. The exact-reference experiment below tests this separate approximation question.

Error against an Exact Reference. Figure 18 uses a 30-qubit TFIM on a 5×6 lattice with an exact state-vector reference, checked against untruncated Pauli propagation on smaller grids. The four-step circuit reaches absolute error 7.2×10^{-5} at cutoff 10^{-7}, with *SectorQ* on 16 GPUs completing in 29.2 s. Implementations with the same truncation rule have the same error at a given cutoff, whereas MonoProp requires a separate error comparison. The six-step circuit reaches time or memory limits at higher cutoffs. Neither sweep has strictly monotonic error at every intermediate cutoff. The large kicked Ising workload has no exact reference at the evaluated scale and is also nonmonotonic. Its values from cutoff 10^{-6} to 1.5×10^{-7} are approximately 0.3217, 0.3256, 0.3265, 0.3226, 0.3153, and 0.3089. Thus, the capacity result extends the accessible truncated computation without asserting convergence or a guaranteed reduction in physical error.

4.6 Parameter Sensitivity and Repeatability

Figure 19 groups parameter changes and repeated measurements to test the stability of the execution behavior.

Sector Granularity and Device Memory. At cutoff 10^{-5}, a target sector size one quarter of the default increases time by 9-26%, whereas twice the target reduces it by 2-9% across the representative circuits. One to four tasks per GPU differ by at most 9%, and eight can increase time by up to



(a) 4 Trotter steps

(b) 6 Trotter steps

Fig. 18. Simulation time and error of a 30-qubit TFIM

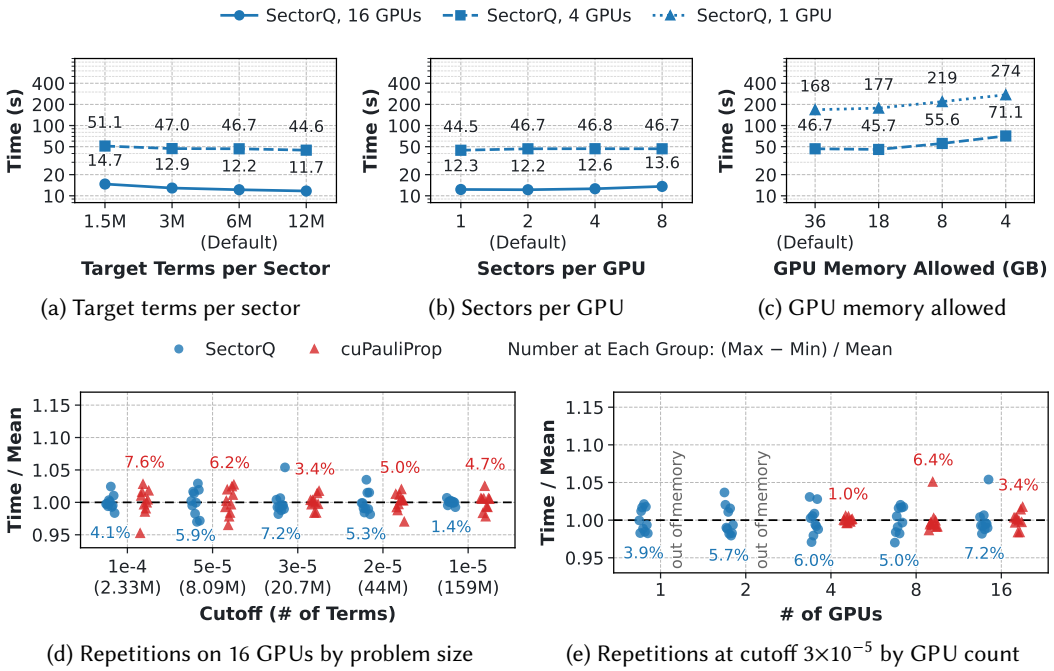
35% on 16 GPUs. The tradeoff is between additional library invocations with small sectors and working-buffer pressure with large sectors. Reducing the device-memory budget from 36 to 4 GB increases time by 12-64% but preserves the tested answers through finer sector execution. More concurrency alone is not sufficient at large scale. A 512-GPU kicked Ising run at 3×10^{-6} with a 4,096-sector cap and smaller host chunks takes 11.6 s, against the default's 9.7 s. This joint change does not isolate the cap and does not establish one configuration as optimal across cluster sizes.

Repeated Measurements. The repetition experiment contains 160 completed kicked Ising runs, with ten measurements per setting. We define spread as maximum minus minimum time divided by their mean. On 16 GPUs, spread is 1.4-7.2% for *SectorQ* and 3.4-7.6% for original-circuit *cuPauliProp*. All repetitions preserve the printed expectation value. Each system's 16-GPU repetitions use one allocation, but the systems use different allocations. This avoids allocation changes within a system's spread while retaining that distinction in the comparison. At cutoff 10^{-5}, the ratio of ten-run means is 7.6, close to the main sweep's single-run ratio of 7.8. Panels (d) and (e) show the repeated times across problem sizes and GPU counts, respectively. The repetition results support the observed performance difference without treating a single-run measurement as a confidence interval.

5 Related Work

The relevant distinctions concern the partition rule, when it changes, and the memory that holds the propagated operator.

Conserved Operator Subspaces. Symmetries and invariant subspaces are established tools in quantum simulation. Bravyi et al. identify binary symmetries of fermionic Hamiltonians and remove qubits after selecting a symmetry sector [4]. West et al. describe a commutator graph whose connected components identify invariant operator subspaces under a set of generators [19]. These results establish the algebraic basis for independent evolution and preclude a novelty claim based on parity conservation alone. *SectorQ* uses binary rows as labels on Pauli strings, with the ordinary binary inner product expressing invariance under generator XOR. The labels are not symmetry eigenvalues of a quantum state, and their sectors need not be individual connected components of the commutator graph. The system derives sufficiently fine labels for a finite window and replaces them when the next window has different generators. This construction supplies an executable partition for distributed merge and truncation without requiring a useful nontrivial partition conserved by the entire circuit.



(a) Target terms per sector (b) Sectors per GPU (c) GPU memory allowed

(d) Repetitions on 16 GPUs by problem size (e) Repetitions at cutoff 3×10^{-5} by GPU count

Fig. 19. Parameter sensitivity at cutoff 10^{-5} and ten repeated measurements of kicked Ising

Fixed Linear Partitions. The closest implementation-level comparison is paulistrings-rs, whose partition label is a binary matrix times the Pauli bit vector [12]. Its linear map identifies one communication partner for each nonlocal generator delta, and its local coset execution already exploits independent groups of strings. The documented partition rows remain fixed during a run, and automatic row selection that accounts for both balance and remote work is listed as an open problem. The parallel iQCC implementation also uses a bitmask to assign Pauli words to processes and computes the destination of a product through XOR [6]. A predictable destination can still be remote. *SectorQ* requires every chosen row to annihilate every generator in the current window, placing all resulting merge partners in one sector throughout that window. It then selects rows again for the next window and schedules sectors from host memory. Our same-engine fixed-row ablation isolates this temporal choice, while the paulistrings-rs comparison measures complete implementations with matched truncation.

Distributed CPU Propagation. ORQA demonstrates large-scale propagation on Fugaku with up to one trillion Pauli strings and 2^{17} processes [5]. Its distribution map is a structured enumeration of string bits designed to limit communication partners while maintaining balance. It is not a generic hash, and the sparsity of its communication is central to its scaling. The map still distributes updates as the propagation advances through generators, rather than deriving a partition conserved by a window. MonoProp provides distributed Pauli and Majorana propagation through a C++ implementation with Python interfaces [1]. These systems establish that large operators can reside in distributed CPU memory. *SectorQ* addresses the additional requirement of executing sectors through GPU kernels while the operator remains in host memory. Our evaluation labels the ORQA implementation as a reproduction, identifies the CPU resources used, and treats MonoProp's different truncation rule separately from comparisons with identical coefficient decisions.

Propagation Libraries and GPU Kernels. Sparse Pauli dynamics and PauliPropagation.jl develop efficient observable simulation and truncation methods [3, 17]. Quantinuum's SPD provides GPU execution, and Qiskit's Pauli propagation package supports Clifford operations, Pauli rotations, and noise channels [15, 16]. These libraries improve the cost and coverage of propagation within their supported execution environments. NVIDIA's *cuPauliProp* supplies GPU operations on sparse Pauli expansions and a distributed execution mode [13]. *SectorQ* uses its single-GPU operations for arithmetic and compares against its original-circuit distributed mode. Consequently, the contribution concerns the locality and storage of those operations, not a replacement arithmetic kernel. The measured element sequence separates Clifford preprocessing and deferred deduplication from window-sector execution. The single-GPU comparison also retains cases in which another implementation is faster. This distinction identifies the system benefit as the ability to execute growing operators across nodes without requiring the complete local expansion to remain in GPU memory.
Repeated Evaluations and Gradients. PADO-Pauli compiles circuits and observables into sparse matrices that are reused for batches of parameter values and supports gradients through PyTorch [9]. Its reuse of a compiled representation targets repeated evaluations during variational training. Backpropagating Pauli Propagation develops gradient evaluation whose computational complexity matches forward propagation and reduces its memory requirements through reversibility [11]. These objectives differ from the single forward propagation measured in our capacity and scaling experiments. *SectorQ* follows the surviving terms of one specified circuit and cutoff, with new rows chosen from those live terms at window boundaries. It neither assumes a fixed sparse program shared by parameter batches nor evaluates derivatives in the reported experiments. The distinction is relevant because a faster batched or gradient evaluation is not directly comparable to the time of a single forward run with the same coefficient truncation. The methods address complementary workloads, and their integration would require a separate numerical and performance evaluation.
Staged State Vector Simulation. State vector simulators already reduce communication through groups of gates. Häner and Steiger schedule gates to reduce communication in a distributed simulation of 45 qubits [8]. Atlas partitions circuits into stages with an integer program, selects kernels with dynamic programming, and supports host-memory offloading [20]. Stage boundaries and host storage are therefore not new independently. Their state vector has a fixed index space, whereas Pauli propagation creates strings, combines equal strings, and removes coefficients during execution. A useful partition must preserve these merges before truncation, and the sizes of its parts depend on the surviving operator. *SectorQ* derives this locality from the window generators and obtains execution granularity from a sample of the live terms. An oversized sector can be subdivided only by rows valid for its remaining operations. This constraint connects host-memory execution to the algebraic partition and distinguishes the proposed mechanism from applying a state-vector stage schedule to a sparse operator.

6 Conclusion

In this paper, we design and implement *SectorQ*, a Pauli propagation system for GPU clusters that partitions the terms by the parities that each window of gates conserves. By recomputing these parities for every window from the generators of its gates and the live terms, we confine the merging of terms to one sector during a window and hold the sectors in host memory. We evaluate *SectorQ* with seven circuits on up to 512 NVIDIA A100 GPUs, reducing the simulation time of *cuPauliProp* by 4.4-9.7× on 16 GPUs and increasing the largest finished problem by 140× on 512 GPUs through exchanges at window boundaries and sectors in host memory.

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